Carl and I

By Robert Olen Butler

Dearest Sweetheart

A line or two hoping they will find you all in good health . . . as for me I am getting worse. I don't think I will live long enough to see your dear face again.

INTRODUCTION

Tuberculosis was one of the leading causes of death in the United States in the early twentieth century. There was no treatment . . . instead, those infected were isolated from society and placed in sanatoriums known as "waiting rooms for death."

What would you do if your spouse contracted the disease, was isolated from you for the rest of time and you were alone to await his unquestionable death? Would you make the same decision as our speaker?

Carl and I by Robert Olen Butler.

Three nights after I married Carl Peterson, we watched Sarah Bernhardt die of consumption on a bed

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strewn with camellias. She was very beautiful, her face a sad white mask, her eyes enormous and dark, her voice rising from the stage and filling the Lyric Theatre. I grasped my Carl's arm on the seat next to me as she died, for he was the one man I had ever loved and now we were married, on the previous Saturday, December 16, 1905, and the church was filled with red camellias.

The newspapers said that Sarah Bernhardt slept in her own coffin, transporting it with her wherever she went, and she had died nearly twenty thousand times in her life, just as she was dying before us, and she took a cloth from her bosom as she lay on her deathbed, and she coughed terribly into it.

Now Carl has written to me from Attleboro that he is dying. He left for the sanitarium barely a month ago and he has lost hope. So quickly. The death is coming upon him very quickly.

He put the postcard in an envelope so the postal carrier would not share his words. *Dearest Sweetheart*, he said to me. I grew weak at this. And he tried hard to put his bravery down on the card, going quite formal for a

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moment. *A line or two hoping they will find you all in good health,* he said. All in good health. Completely in good health. As I seem, in fact, to be, which gives me no comfort. *As for me,* he said, *I am getting worse. I don't think I will live long enough to see your dear face again.*

He turned his face to me when we tucked the quilts around him in the backseat of the automobile that came to take him. He was as white as Sarah Bernhardt dying in the Lyric Theatre.

not. I have kept all the postcards Carl has sent to me. They are in a teakwood box. He wooed me with postcards. And he continued to write them even after we were married. He would be at work and I would come home from the library before him, and waiting in the mailbox would be a card from him. *Oh, you sweetheart,* he wrote. This was not so very long ago. His face was white and his eyes were terrible dark when he left for Attleboro.

I must write him now in return. He will not let me come to visit. He says I've been exposed long enough to the contagion, he could not bear for me to get sick. And

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he doesn't say it, but he's ashamed of how he's grown weak, how he's lost so much weight. He has always been a man to take off his coat and roll up his sleeves and have at some physical thing. My only recourse is a penny postcard that lies before me now in the center of the little flattop desk in our bedroom. I've chosen a card of a woman sitting with her hands clasped around a knee and her eyes are cast down and beneath her is the printed word *heartbroken.* I am, in fact, heartbroken. Carl will understand.

I look out the open window and across the yard to the sugar maple and to the laundry I'd hung this afternoon, the sheets and my nightgowns and underskirts and two of his dress shirts and I cannot look at his shirts. I'm finding more things I cannot look at in this house. The overstuffed armchair in our front room where he would read his newspaper of the evening. The porch swing. The cotton handkerchief near my feet. I wish I'd found it before I'd done the laundry. It was caught in the narrow dark space between the wall and his bed, near the headboard. It is folded tightly over

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the things he brought up from his lungs in his last days in our home. I can see the stains, the color of dried camellias. I found it an hour ago and dropped it at once and I washed my hands, as Carl would wish me to do.

I have filled my fountain pen. I turn the card over.

I look at it for a long time, its blank, divided back.

My mind is seizing idly on this and that. The ticking of the clock from the front room. The stirring of the maple tree. We first kissed under a vast maple tree, Carl and I. Decoration Day, 1904. We'd met in a late March snow that year. I came out of the general store and I had my shopping bag clutched to my chest. The air was unexpectedly full of snow and I was dazzled by this. I lifted my face as I stepped out and turned and I even closed my eyes to let the flakes fall on my eyelids and I ran into Carl Peterson, a great tall oak of a man whose arms went around me even before I had looked into his face. As soon as I was steady on my feet he withdrew and we looked into each other's face and he did not

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seem particularly handsome to me in those first moments. I am an overly critical sort, I think. It is my nature. His eyes were rather too close together and his face too round and too ruddy and though he was clearly a young man, he had deep-shadowed furrows across his brow above his nose and defining his cheeks from nose to lips. I would come to love these places on his face. Even when I had long prayed for that ruddiness to return, and when his face had begun to go gaunt, I would lie beside him and run my fingertip in these places and he would close his eyes and perhaps dream of how we met.

He suddenly bent forward and I took a step back, startled.

Then he rose up with the tinned milk that had fallen from my bag. "I make these," he said. "Well, so to speak," he said, lifting the can and considering it, his lower lip pushing up thoughtfully.

"I'd say cows made those."

"Well now, miss, do you think the cows run all the kettles and vacuum pans and heating chambers and

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cooling tanks to make this stuff pure and safe?"

"So the cows work for you?"

"And then there's the canning." He lifted the tinned milk high. "No cow can do a double seam on a tin can."

"All right, I'm prepared to give you credit. . . . You own the company, do you?"

He drew up to full height and he laid the can in the center of his chest. "Please," he said. "I'm a proud member of the working class, which does the real work. Neither cow nor tycoon can usurp our importance." He paused to let that sink in for a moment and I duly stood there looking up at him, agape. Then he winked at me and said, "I *am* a foreman, however."

And that was how we met, Carl Peterson and I. And we kissed under a maple tree up along a creek where we lingered, sitting on a log, and we talked, and there were daisies all around . . . and this was Decoration Day, 1904.

I slept in the yard last night in a reclining chair, my body swaddled like Carl's. I want to share this

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sanitarium life of his. Yesterday I ate raw eggs and milk and did exercises, moderately, morning and evening, and I lay in that chair under the sky all day long, trying to think of nothing, resting my body and mind, resting completely and activating my body's own defenses out in the fresh pure air.

On the day we found out for sure that our worst fears about his persistent cough, his afternoon flush, his weakness were true-this was still before the blood-on that day, Dr. Gilbert, sat behind his massive desk and his glasses hung round his neck on a cord and he told us straight out. "Mr. Peterson, you have tuberculosis of the lungs."

I was calm, at this. And, of course, Carl was calm. We had known for a while, though the words had never been spoken between us. Carl and I held hands before Dr. Gilbert, who was going on in a voice tainted with sarcasm, "These bacilli, though they may well exist, must necessarily fall on favorable soil, fertile soil, to grow and live. So we must build up the soil."

He had used the same metaphor-apparently the

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only one he knew-when he'd told me the year before that my ovaries were not properly formed and my womb was tilted. So I cannot have children? I said, not really a question. You have no fertile soil, he said. I imagine him bending over a man suffering a heart attack to say, Your heart lacks fertile soil for beating. He is a fool with his words.

I held Carl the night we discovered my barrenness and for several nights thereafter. I held him till morning, my arms around him as if to cradle him. We both shed tears, though with no sounds, no words about this turn of events. There would be no children for us.

Though so many die young, anyway. When yellow fever and cholera and smallpox aren't going around, there's always influenza and pneumonia and typhus and scarlet fever and measles and whooping cough and diphtheria, to name a few, and there is always a bit of poisoned meat or milk or something else that a child can eat and die from, and, of course, there is tuberculosis. Let *us* die then, Carl and I, but not a child. It's better for us not to have a child than to bear a child that will

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die young, is it not?

It is not. But I have no other consolation.

I rise up from my desk. The postcard is still blank, except for my husband's name and his final address in this world, the Attleboro Sanitarium. I cross the room and stand in the doorway from the bedroom to the living room. I wait for another thought. I wait for words to say to my husband.

We were so careful. He was always a careful consumptive, even at home, and I let him. I regret that. Standing now looking at our bed I understand that I should have kissed him more. I should have turned his face to me when he was coughing so terribly in the night and I should have taken his face in my hands and kissed him in that moment when he needed something no one could give. I should have kissed him on the lips.

I move to the desk now. I sit. I pick up my pen. I think to call him sweetheart. I think to say, *My darling I love you and always will. I kiss your dear face, your darling lips.* But I write none of this. These are foolish words. They have nothing to do with the life Carl and I now share.

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And then I know what to say: *We'll meet in death.*

And I know what to do. I put the pen down and I push my chair back and I bend to the handkerchief on the floor. I hold it with my two hands, Carl's handkerchief, and I unfold it. I expose the remnants of his tortured breath and I lift it to my face. And I breathe in, deeply. I breathe into myself my husband's life, and I pray that I am fertile soil.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Olen Butler
Book: Had a Good Time
ISBN: 978-0802117779
Publisher: Atlantic Monthly Press
Date (Month/Year): July 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier

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